Retrieval practice

Strengthening recall

Use retrieval practice to strengthen access to previously taught knowledge. Students should attempt to generate the answer from memory before they see notes, prompts or the solution.

How to do it well

1 Select important taught knowledge. Identify the facts, relationships or process steps students need to retain, and write prompts that retrieve them directly.

2 Choose the delay. Revisit recent and older learning so recall involves some effort while remaining achievable.

3 Protect generation. Set a silent independent attempt, keeping solutions hidden and controlling when prompts become available.

4 Give corrective feedback. Compare answers with an accurate model, repair misunderstandings and let students attempt a related item.

5 Schedule the return. Bring fragile knowledge back in later lessons, quizzes or homework, varying the cue while keeping the learning focus clear.

What this sounds like

“Try from memory first. Leave your notes closed. Afterwards we will compare with the model and identify which parts need another retrieval attempt.”

Classroom example. After teaching photosynthesis, a Biology teacher later asks pupils to reconstruct the word equation from memory. Students attempt before the model appears. Feedback clarifies a common confusion between a reactant and product. A later question uses a different cue so pupils retrieve the relationship again rather than remember the position of words on a slide.

Top tips that make the technique work

Match retrieval to the knowledge. Use definitions, explanations, diagrams, short procedures and comparisons where each rehearses the intended content.

Teach before testing recall. Repeated failure on untaught or poorly understood material will not repair the original explanation.

Keep the attempt low stakes. Errors reveal what to revisit; avoid creating anxiety through public rankings.

Show useful feedback. Include the reasoning or worked steps where a final answer alone would leave the error unresolved.

Use later retrieval. A correct answer immediately after teaching does not establish durable recall.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Require an independent attempt before revealing answers.	Replacing retrieval with rereading.
Revisit important gaps after feedback.	Counting copied corrections as successful recall.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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